



The Journal for Cultural and Religious Theory (JCRT)

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Religion and Modernity in Current Debate

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Pecora - Religion and Modernity in Current Debate - JCRT 4.2

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Any attempt to talk briefly about such immense subjects as “religion” and “modernity” is a foolhardy enterprise at best, and I take up this task with many misgivings. But in the wake of the events of September 11, 2001, a subsequent “war” focused mainly on what is now widely perceived to be global networks of religious (that is, primarily Islamic) terrorism, including renewed armed struggle between Palestinians and Israelis the religious elements of which cannot be ignored, it is hard not to go once again where better angels might fear to tread. The recent American invasion of Iraq has made the task of re-thinking the relationship of modernity and religion all the more pressing, since it now appears that a secular Western power with a still vibrant Christian culture the United States will attempt to create *ex nihilo* a new government and civil society in Iraq, which was once the cradle of Islamic civilization. The resurgence of a lively discussion about a “clash of civilizations,” the invocation of “crusades” and *jihads*, and the large body of assumptions about the secular nature of the contemporary West and the religious sensibility of those who oppose it assumptions that appear on both sides of this divide make it almost impossible, I think, for informed people not to wonder once again about the complicated relationship between the so-called “modern world” and religious belief.

> The New York and Washington suicide bombers seem to have been middle-class, educated men, not

In such models, US retaliation in Afghanistan and the larger Western focus on Islam as the key called fundamentalist, less rationalized forms of religion in Palestine, Saudi Arabia, Afghanistan left mainly an ambiguous consequence of neocolonialism.

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Notes

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Updated 07/28/21.

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